

perspective to the finances. But the specific problems must be dealt with first. Then we'll decide who should do what.

"I need to get an idea about where you are financially right now, so I'm going to ask you some questions, Ben. Feel free to speak up, Naomi, if you think Ben has missed anything or you have some input."

Bryan took out one of his budget worksheets and started down the list of monthly expenses. Ben gave most of the answers, but when it came to regular expenses, such as those for clothes, food, laundry, and childcare, he deferred to Naomi's better memory.

When they had completed the list, the coach began to list their outstanding debts. Once they had gone through the obvious debts—the house mortgage, credit union loan, car loans, and family loans—Ben was noticeably hesitant.

"What's the problem, Ben?" Bryan asked, sensing that Ben was holding back.

"I need to tell you something," Ben said hesitantly, "but I'm afraid Naomi will really get upset if I do."

"I can't help you unless I know all the facts," Bryan said. "If you owe something else that's not reflected in our records, you must let me know about it."

"Well, about two months ago, when Naomi and I were having a lot of problems, I bought a new car," Ben confessed.

"You bought a new car!" Naomi exclaimed. "How did you buy a new car? I've never seen it."

"Naomi, give Ben a chance to explain," Bryan cautioned. "He's trying to be honest with you now."

"I bought the car from a local dealer with the understanding that I could return it if Naomi wanted me to. When I got home, that was the day we had a big fight about our Visa account being turned over to a collection agency, remember? So I tried to return the car. That's when I found out that the dealer wanted \$650 to take it back."